

THREE OLD MEN

The Last Conversation



A Novel by
Anirach Mingkhwan

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Three Old Men: The Last Conversation

By Anirach Mingkhwan

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*everyone who has loved and lost,
and found the courage to keep talking anyway.*

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Preface

They say that when old men gather, they talk about the past. But that's only half true.

When old men gather—truly old men, the kind who have outlived wars and wives and most of their certainties—they talk about everything. They argue about the price of rice and the nature of God. They laugh at jokes that would make younger people uncomfortable. They cry sometimes, though they'd never admit it later.

This is a story about three such men.

I won't tell you their real names. They wouldn't have wanted that. What I will tell you is that they met every week for decades at the same tea house, at the same table by the window where the afternoon light fell just right. They ordered the same things—jasmine tea for one, chrysanthemum for another, and plain hot water for the third, who always claimed tea was “too much fuss.”

They talked about time and love, about control and suffering, about all the things they'd done wrong and the few things they'd done right. They talked about death with the casual familiarity of men who could see it approaching like an old acquaintance walking down the street.

This book is not a transcription of their conversations. How could it be? I wasn't there for most of them, and memory is a river that changes its course with every retelling.

What this is, instead, is my attempt to capture something true—the way three men who had nothing left to prove and nothing left to lose finally said the things that mattered.

The tea house closed three years ago. The table by the window is gone.

But the conversations continue.

They always do, if you know how to listen.

Anirach Mingkhwan

February 2026

CHAPTER ONE

The Nature of Time

In which three old men gather and discover that clocks lie



The tea house sat on the corner of Charoen Krung Road, where it had been sitting for sixty-seven years, watching the city grow tall around it like bamboo overtaking a garden. It had survived floods and coups and the relentless march of progress, and now it remained—stubborn, wooden, slightly crooked—sandwiched between a massage parlor and a 7-Eleven that hummed with fluorescent indifference.

Inside, at the table by the window where the afternoon light fell in long golden stripes, three old men were arguing about clocks.

“The trouble with clocks,” said Somchai, stirring his jasmine tea with the slow deliberation of a man who had nowhere else to be, “is that they lie to us from the moment we're born.”

Prasert snorted. He was a compact man with steel-gray hair and the permanently skeptical face of someone who had spent forty years as an engineer, fixing other people's mistakes. “Clocks don't lie. Clocks are machines. Machines do exactly what they're built to do.”

“And what are they built to do?” Somchai asked, his weathered face crinkling into something that might have been a smile or might have been the prelude to a trap.

“Tell time. Obviously.”

“Ah.” Somchai lifted his teacup. “But do they? Or do they merely count? Tick, tick, tick. One second, then another, then another. They show us numbers changing on a dial. But time—real time, the time we actually live—has nothing to do with those numbers.”

“Here we go,” muttered Prasert into his chrysanthemum tea.

The third man at the table—Anong, the oldest of the three, who wore the dreamy, distant look of someone whose mind wandered often through the halls of memory—leaned forward with sudden interest.

“You know,” Anong said, his voice carrying the slight tremor of age, “I was thinking about my granddaughter's wedding last week. Or was it last month? Anyway, I was thinking about it, and I remembered my own wedding like it was yesterday. Noi in her white dress. The way she looked at

me when I forgot my vows and had to invent something on the spot.”

He chuckled, and the chuckle became a cough, and the cough subsided into silence.

“That was fifty-three years ago,” Anong went on. “But in my mind I can touch it. I can smell the jasmine flowers in her hair. I can hear her laugh when I called her the wrong name—I was so nervous, you see, I called her by her sister’s name, and she never let me forget it, not once in forty-eight years of marriage.”

He paused, and his eyes went distant.

“Forty-eight years. The clock says it was forty-eight years. But it felt like one long afternoon. One beautiful afternoon that ended too soon.”

Prasert shifted, uncomfortable. He never knew what to do when Anong talked about Noi. Five years she had been gone, and still Anong spoke of her in the present tense as often as not.

“What Somchai is trying to say—” Prasert began.

“I’m not trying to say anything,” Somchai interrupted mildly. “I’m saying it. The clock is a liar. It tells us time moves at a constant rate, one second per second, steady and reliable. But we know better, don’t we? We’ve lived long enough to know.”

He gestured toward the window, where the late afternoon light was turning the old wooden frames to gold.

“When you were young, Prasert—when you were building your bridges and your buildings and all those things you were so proud of—did time feel the way it does now?”

Prasert opened his mouth to argue, then closed it. He thought of the twenty-hour days he used to work, the way weeks blurred together in a rush of deadlines and concrete and the satisfaction of making something stand where nothing had stood before.

“It was different,” he admitted, reluctant. “But that’s only perception. The actual time—”

“There is no ‘actual’ time,” Somchai said. “There’s only the time we live. And that time expands and contracts like a living thing.”

“Like a heartbeat,” Anong said suddenly. “My grandmother used to say time had a heartbeat. When you’re happy, it beats fast, rushing to the end of the joy. When you’re sad, it slows, trying to give you room to feel everything.”

“Your grandmother was very poetic,” Somchai said, approving.

“Your grandmother was full of nonsense,” Prasert said, but not unkindly.

“No offense to her memory.”

“She would have liked you,” Anong said, smiling. “She always said she trusted a man who argued with her more than a man who agreed too easily.”



The waiter came by—a young man in his twenties who moved with the impatient energy of someone with many other places he’d rather be. He refilled their teapots without asking and vanished again, his sneakers squeaking against the worn wooden floor.

“He’s in a hurry,” Anong observed. “I remember being in a hurry. Always running to the next thing, the next customer, the next shipment. I owned seventeen fishing boats at one point—did I ever tell you?”

“Several thousand times,” Prasert said drily.

“Seventeen boats, and every one of them needed something. New nets. Engine repairs. Crews who didn’t drink too much and show up late. I used to wake at four in the morning and not stop moving until midnight.”

“And now?” Somchai asked.

Anong laughed—a gentle, self-deprecating sound. “Now I wake at four in the morning because my bladder insists on it, and I move as little as I can. Strange, isn’t it? I spent sixty years running around like a madman, and what did it get me? The same destination as everyone else. An old man at a tea house, waiting.”

“Waiting for what?” Prasert asked.

It was meant as a challenge, but Anong took it seriously. He looked out the window at the street below, where motorcycles wove between cars and a fruit vendor was setting up her cart with practiced efficiency.

“I don’t know anymore,” he said quietly. “I used to wait for things. For success. For my children to make me proud. For Noi to look at me the way she did when we were young.” He paused. “Now I think I’m just waiting for the waiting to end.”

The silence that followed was the kind only old friends can share—weighted with understanding, empty of judgment.

“That’s morbid,” Prasert said at last.

“That’s honest,” Somchai corrected.

“Same thing, at our age.”



Somchai reached into his pocket and brought out a small object—a worn

pocket watch, the brass gone green with age, the crystal scratched and cloudy. He set it on the table between them.

"My father gave me this when I turned twenty," he said. "He said it had belonged to his father, and his father before him. Four generations of men, all watching the same hands go round and round."

Prasert leaned forward despite himself. He had known Somchai for nearly thirty years, and in all that time he had never seen the watch.

"Does it still work?"

"Oh, it runs." Somchai wound the crown gently, and the watch began to tick—a soft, intimate sound, like a whisper in a quiet room. "But it loses about three minutes a day. Has since before I was born. My great-grandfather dropped it during the war—no one remembers which war—and it's never been the same."

"So it's useless," Prasert said.

"On the contrary. It's the most honest clock I've ever known."

"Because it's wrong?"

"Because it admits it's wrong." Somchai lifted the watch and held it to his ear, listening to the tick. "Every clock is wrong, Prasert. Every single one. They all drift, all lose or gain, all fall slowly out of step with the arbitrary standard we've agreed to call 'real' time. Most clocks pretend otherwise. They show us their numbers with such confidence, such certainty. But this old thing—" he smiled, "—this old thing knows better. It knows it's only counting, and that the counting means nothing."

"If time means nothing, then what's the point of anything?" Prasert demanded. "Why plan? Why build? Why bother?"

"Ah." Somchai set the watch down again. "Now you're asking the right questions."



Anong was staring at the watch with an expression Prasert couldn't quite read.

"You know what I think about," Anong said slowly, "when I can't sleep at night? Which is most nights now—old men don't sleep well, have you noticed?"

"I've noticed," Prasert said.

"I think about the time I wasted." Anong's voice was soft, almost wondering. "Not the big things—I don't regret working hard or building the business or any of that. But the small things. The hours I spent worrying about problems that never came. The days I was angry about things that

don't matter anymore. The years—years!—I spent thinking about the future instead of noticing the present."

"That's what young people do," Somchai said gently. "They have to. If they didn't think about the future, nothing would ever get built or planted or raised."

"But they don't know the cost," Anong said. "I didn't know. Nobody told me that every minute I spent planning for later was a minute I gave up from now. And now—" he gestured vaguely at himself, at his fragile body, at the liver spots on his hands, "—now 'now' is all I have, and I don't have much of it left."

"Nobody knows how much they have left," Prasert said, uneasy with the direction of the conversation. "That's true at any age."

"But at our age, we can make reasonable estimates." Anong smiled, and there was something both sad and free in it. "When I was forty, I could tell myself I might live another forty years. It was probably true! But now? If I get five more years, I'll be lucky. If I get ten, I'll be amazed. If I get twenty—" he laughed, "—I'll start believing in miracles."

"Or medicine," Prasert muttered.

"Medicine can give you time," Somchai said. "It can't give you presence. It can't give you the ability to actually be in the moments you have left."

"Is that what you're doing?" Prasert asked, genuinely curious despite his skepticism. "Being present?"

Somchai weighed the question with the seriousness it deserved.

"I'm trying," he said at last. "It's harder than you'd think. After seventy-five years of learning to live in the future—planning, hoping, fearing, anticipating—it's very hard to stop. The mind doesn't want to rest. It wants to keep running ahead, scouting for danger, hunting for opportunity."

"The mind is a good servant but a bad master," Anong said, then frowned. "Who said that? I'm sure I read it somewhere."

"Does it matter who said it?" Somchai asked. "The truth is the truth, whether it comes from a sage or a street vendor."

"I'd trust the street vendor more," Prasert said. "At least she's trying to give you something useful."



The light through the window was changing now, the gold deepening to amber as the afternoon began its slow surrender to evening. In the street below, the fruit vendor had finished setting up and was calling out prices in a melodic singsong that drifted up through the old wooden walls.

"I've been thinking about my mother lately," Somchai said, seemingly out of nowhere.

The other two waited. They had known Somchai long enough to know that his apparent non sequiturs usually led somewhere.

"She died when I was twelve," he went on. "I remember the day very clearly—not the whole day, but pieces of it. The way the light came through the hospital window. The smell of the antiseptic. The sound of my father crying, which I had never heard before and haven't heard since."

He paused, gathering himself.

"I'm seventy-five years old now. That means my mother has been dead for sixty-three years. Sixty-three years! And yet when I think of her, she's as present as either of you. More present, maybe, because I've carried her in my heart longer than I've known you."

"That's sweet," Anong said, and meant it.

"It's strange is what it is," Somchai said. "Sixty-three years, and time hasn't touched her at all. She's still thirty-four years old. She still has that smile she used to save just for me, the one she gave me when I brought her flowers I'd picked from the neighbor's garden. She still tells me to sit up straight and eat my vegetables and be kind to people who are unkind to me."

"The dead don't age," Prasert said. "That's not philosophy—that's just how memory works."

"But what is memory except a form of time travel?" Somchai asked. "When I think of my mother, I'm there with her again. Not just remembering—being. For a moment I'm twelve years old again, and she's alive, and everything is possible."

"And then you come back," Prasert said flatly. "And you're seventy-five, and she's still dead, and everything is exactly as it was before."

"Yes," Somchai allowed. "But for that moment—that eternal, timeless moment—the clock was wrong. Sixty-three years had passed, and also no time at all."

Anong was nodding hard. "Yes, yes, that's exactly it. When I think of Noi—when I really think of her, not just remember but think—she's right here. I can feel her hand in mine. I can hear her telling me I forgot to lock the back door, the way she did every night for forty-eight years."

"You probably did forget," Prasert said.

"I almost certainly did. But that's not the point."

"What is the point?"

Anong looked at him with surprising directness. "The point, old friend, is that the people we love don't go away. They can't. They're woven into us. Every time we think of them, they're alive again. Every time we hear their voice in our heads or feel them in a room, they've defeated time. They've come back from wherever they went."

"That's comforting," Prasert said. "It's also nonsense."

"Why can't it be both?"



The waiter returned with fresh hot water for Anong's plain cup—because Anong, true to form, refused to drink anything so frivolous as tea and insisted on plain hot water, like some kind of ascetic monk, though he would have laughed at the comparison.

"Thank you," Anong said, and the waiter nodded and disappeared again.

"He doesn't know us," Anong observed. "We've been coming here for thirty years, and he doesn't know our names or our stories or anything about us."

"Why should he?" Prasert asked. "We're just three old men taking up a table."

"We're the whole universe," Somchai said mildly.

Prasert rolled his eyes. "Here we go again."

"I mean it. From his side, we're background. Furniture. But from ours, we're the center of everything. Every thought we've ever had, every feeling, every experience—it's all here, inside these three creaky old bodies. When we die, universes die with us."

"Cheerful thought, over tea."

"It's not meant to be cheerful or uncheerful. It's simply true. And it bears on time, which is what we were talking about."

"Were we? I lost track."

"We were. And my point is this: the time we live—the only time that matters—is entirely internal. The clock on the wall says it's half past five in the afternoon, and that's true for everyone. But the time inside us—the weight of years, the depth of moments, the way certain seconds stretch into eternities while whole decades vanish like dreams—that's unique to each of us. Incomparable. Incommunicable."

"If it's incommunicable, why are we talking about it?" Prasert asked, though there was no real challenge in his voice anymore. He was, despite himself, interested.

“Because talking is how we remind ourselves we’re not alone,” Somchai said. “Even if we can’t truly share our inner lives, we can wave at each other across the distance. We can say: ‘I’m here too. I’m also confused. I’m also running out of time.’”



Anong had been quiet for a while, watching the street below with an expression of peaceful melancholy. Now he turned back to his friends with a question that seemed to surprise even him.

“If you could go back to any moment in your life—not to change anything, just to be there again—where would you go?”

Prasert shifted in his seat. “That’s a ridiculous hypothetical.”

“Humor me. I’m old and easily entertained.”

“Fine.” Prasert thought about it, his engineer’s mind trying to optimize the problem. “The day we finished the Siriraj Bridge. 1983. I’d worked on it for three years, and when we finally ran the load test and everything held—he smiled despite himself, “—I felt like I could conquer anything.”

“Professional achievement,” Anong said. “I should have guessed.”

“What about you?”

Anong didn’t hesitate. “The birth of my first son. Not the birth itself—that was terrifying, all that blood and screaming. But the moment after, when the nurse laid him in my arms and he looked at me with those little unfocused eyes, and I knew I would die for this tiny creature without a second thought.”

“And you?” Prasert asked Somchai. “What moment would you choose?”

Somchai was quiet so long that Prasert wondered if he’d heard the question. At last he spoke.

“No moment in particular.”

“That’s not an answer.”

“It’s the only answer I have.” Somchai folded his hands on the table, his long fingers laced together. “I’ve thought about this question a lot, actually. More than you’d expect. And I’ve come to see that the moment I’d choose isn’t a moment at all. It’s a quality of moments.”

“Meaning?”

“Meaning there were times in my life when I was fully present. Not thinking about the past, not worrying about the future, just... there. Completely there, in my body, in the world, awake to everything. Those moments could come at any time—while teaching a class, while walking

home in the rain, while doing nothing at all. And if I could go back, I’d go back to that quality. That presence. Not to any particular scene, but to that way of being.”

“That’s very abstract,” Prasert said.

“That’s very honest,” Anong corrected.

“Can you tell them apart anymore?”



The sun was setting now, painting the sky in shades of orange and pink that glanced off the glass towers that had grown up around the tea house like a forest of steel and light. Below, the fruit vendor was packing up her cart, counting her money, getting ready for the long motorcycle ride home.

“We should probably go,” Prasert said, though he made no move to rise.

“Probably,” Anong agreed, also not moving.

“The trouble with leaving,” Somchai said, “is that we can never come back to exactly this moment. This light. This conversation. This feeling of being together.”

“We come back every week,” Prasert pointed out.

“We come back to the tea house. We sit at this table. But the moment is always different. The river of time has moved on, and we’re standing on a different bank.”

“You and your rivers.”

“I’m a simple man. I like water metaphors.”

Anong laughed—a warm, genuine sound that made the other two smile despite themselves.

“You know what I love about us?” Anong said. “We’ve been doing this for thirty years, and we still don’t agree about anything.”

“We agree about some things,” Prasert said.

“Name one.”

Prasert opened his mouth, closed it, opened it again. “We agree that this is a good table.”

“That’s not philosophy.”

“Philosophy is overrated. This table has good light and is far enough from the kitchen that you can actually have a conversation. That’s worth more than all of Somchai’s abstractions.”

“I’ll take that as a compliment,” Somchai said serenely.

“It wasn’t meant as one.”

“I know. I’m taking it anyway.”



At last, reluctantly, the three old men began the slow business of gathering themselves to leave. This was no simple operation. There were bills to be sorted (Prasert always insisted on paying his exact share, down to the satang, while Anong always tried to pay for everyone, and Somchai simply let them argue until they wore themselves out). There were joints to be tested carefully before any weight went on them. There were the inevitable trips to the restroom, taken one at a time while the others waited with patient understanding.

“Same time next week?” Anong asked as they shuffled toward the door.

“Same time next week,” Somchai confirmed.

“Assuming we’re all still here,” Prasert added, because he liked to keep things realistic.

“We’ll be here,” Anong said with sudden certainty. “We always are.”

They stepped out into the evening air, warm and thick with exhaust and cooking smells and the particular scent of Bangkok at dusk—a mingling of jasmine and diesel and something indefinably alive.

“The city has changed,” Anong said, looking up at the towers that surrounded them.

“Everything changes,” Somchai said.

“Except us,” Prasert said drily. “We’ve been having the same conversation for thirty years.”

“That’s not true. The conversation changes. We change. Only the arguing stays the same.”

“I’ll take that,” Prasert said. “Arguments keep you sharp.”

“Arguments keep you stubborn.”

“Same thing, at our age.”

They parted at the corner, each heading toward his own home through streets they had walked a thousand times before. Night was falling, the neon signs were flickering to life, and the clock on the bank across the street said it was 6:47 PM.

But the clock, as they all knew by now, was lying.

It was always lying.

The only true time was the time inside them—the weight of years, the

warmth of friendship, the strange certainty that, despite all evidence to the contrary, this particular moment would last forever.

It wouldn’t, of course.

Nothing does.

But walking home through the Bangkok twilight, each of the three old men held onto that feeling anyway—the feeling of having been fully present, just for an afternoon, with people who understood.

The clock could count whatever it liked.

This was what time actually felt like.



End of Chapter One